

ECTLC Lesson Plan: Breaking Generational Patterns

Length: ~35–40 minutes (includes video)

Audience: Participants in ECTLC program

1. Welcome & Hook (3 min)

- Start with a quick story:
“When I was younger, I realized I was repeating things I saw in my parents. Anger. Addiction. Fear. I didn’t mean to—but it came naturally. Has anyone here ever caught yourself doing the same?”
- Quick show of hands or one-word responses: *“Yes, I’ve seen it.”*

2. Scripture Foundation (5 min)

Read aloud (plain language, volunteers can read):

- **Exodus 34:7** – Family sins and struggles can affect future generations.
- **Ezekiel 18:20** – But each person is responsible for their own choices.
- **2 Corinthians 5:17** – In Christ, you are brand new.

Discussion Question: *“What do these verses tell us about both the problem and the hope?”*

3. Video: Renata Merino – Breaking Generational Patterns (8:12 min)

- Play the TEDx Talk video.
- Afterward ask:
“What part of her story felt most familiar to you?”

4. Why Patterns Repeat (4 min)

- Explain: *“We repeat what we saw growing up—good or bad.”*
- **Examples:**
 - A parent’s addiction → child is more vulnerable to addiction.
 - A house full of yelling → yelling feels normal.
 - A praying family → faith is passed on.

Group Reflection: *“What’s one pattern you’ve noticed in your family?”* (Volunteers can share).

5. Breaking the Cycle – 8 Steps (12 min)

Write these on the whiteboard or hand out a sheet:

1. **Identify the Pattern** – Notice the repeated struggles.
2. **Investigate Your Story** – Ask questions, learn your family’s history.

3. **Feel the Feelings** – It's okay to process anger, sadness, grief.
4. **Forgive and Let Go** – For your freedom, not to excuse others.
5. **Protect Your Peace** – Boundaries keep you safe and strong.
6. **Self-Awareness** – Recognize when you're slipping back into old habits.
7. **Accountability** – Be honest, do the work, let others hold you to it.
8. **Seek Help** – Mentors, groups, professionals (no shame in asking).

Interactive Activity:

- Give everyone **2 minutes** to write down *one pattern they want to break*.
- Pair up (or small groups) and share if comfortable.

6. Testimony Illustration (3 min)

- Share **Jessica's story** (from video summary): She saw her parents fight constantly. As an adult, she avoided conflict, always running away. Once she recognized the pattern, she started choosing differently.
- Tie-in: *"Like Jessica, once you see the pattern, you can choose a new path."*

7. Closing & Prayer (5 min)

- Recap: *"Patterns may run in your family, but they don't have to run through you. Jesus makes you new."*
- Re-read **2 Corinthians 5:17** as a declaration.
- Lead prayer: *"Lord, help us to recognize the patterns, forgive where needed, and live in the freedom You give as new creations."*

Time Breakdown (approx.)

- Welcome & Hook – 3 min
- Scripture Foundation – 5 min
- Video – 8 min
- Why Patterns Repeat – 4 min
- Breaking the Cycle (8 Steps + Activity) – 12 min
- Testimony Illustration – 3 min
- Closing & Prayer – 5 min

Total: ~40 minutes